

The Heart in Formation:

Affective Taxonomy as a Framework for Heart Training

The Larger Project and Where This Fits

In a previous paper (Tittle, 2024), I proposed a theological anthropology built on four distinct but interrelated dimensions of the inner person: heart, soul, mind, and spirit, with the body treated separately as a related extension. The argument was that each of the four is real, scriptural, and trainable — and that serious spiritual formation requires attending to all four with intentionality, not just collapsing everything into cognitive development or generic “discipleship.” That paper laid the conceptual foundation. This one takes the next step by testing whether the Affective Taxonomy (Krathwohl et al., 1964) can serve as a framework for defining objectives and measuring progress, specifically in heart formation.

The larger horizon — and I want to keep this visible, not save it for a footnote — is an integrated formation framework where the Cognitive Taxonomy maps to mind training, the Psychomotor Taxonomy maps to body training, and developed taxonomies for the heart, soul, and spirit complete the picture. That would give coaches and disciples a common language across all dimensions of the person, which is something the field currently lacks. This paper is the heart piece. The soul and spirit pieces come next.

Why the heart specifically, and why now? Because the heart, understood as the seat of motivation, desire, and what we might call “the direction of the will” (Willard, 2002), is where affective development actually lives. Krathwohl et al. (1964) defined the affective domain as the territory of values, attitudes, and interests, and organized it as a continuum of deepening internalization. That maps remarkably well onto what Dallas Willard calls the renovation of the heart: a progressive transformation of what a person loves and therefore does.

What Spiritual Formation Is Actually Measuring

Spiritual formation has no shortage of definitions, but they converge on a common scriptural mandate: growing up into Christ (Eph. 4:13), which Jesus summarized as loving God and neighbor (Mark 12:30). Willard (2002) offers perhaps the most useful structural account — six integrated dimensions of the person, all organized around God, with spiritual formation as the process of bringing them into alignment. Foster (1978) organized the classical disciplines into

inner, outer, and corporate categories, and whatever framework one uses, reflective engagement with scripture shows up consistently as foundational.

The harder question is measurement. Hall (2017) administered the Spiritual Transformation Inventory to over 28,000 students at Christian colleges and found genuine progress in prayer disciplines alongside declining bible engagement — a finding that should concern anyone serious about formation. Hancock et al. (2005) at George Fox University developed their own instrument when none of the existing tools fit their culture well enough, eventually settling on a single-dimension measure of Christ-centered living. These efforts matter, but they tend to measure outcomes without a clear developmental model linking objectives to progression. The Affective Taxonomy offers exactly that kind of model.

An influential church-based research on spiritual progression is Hawkins and Parkinson's (2011) MOVE study, which identified four distinguishable growth stages in the movement toward loving God and neighbor, along with the activities and practices that catalyze each stage and each transition. Critically, their research found one practice that supports every stage and every transition equally: reflective bible study. Not generic bible reading — reflective study, the kind that moves from observation to interpretation to life application. That single finding is the pivot point for the pilot test I'm proposing here, because it gives us a tractable, focused target: the progressive deepening of a disciple's trust in scripture as a trustworthy guide for Christlike living.

Why Trust in Scripture Is the Right Test Case

Barna (2003) defines a biblical worldview as beginning with one foundational commitment — the acceptance that absolute moral truth exists and is conveyed through scripture — and extending to six specific biblical statements. Only six percent of American adults hold this foundation. That's a formation problem, and it's an affective one more than a cognitive one. Knowing what the Bible says is not the same as trusting it. The movement from awareness to full incorporation of scripture into a person's worldview is exactly the kind of progressive internalization the Affective Taxonomy was designed to map.

The connection to the spirit and soul dimensions of the person comes in here as well. Willard (2012) argues that hearing God is a whole-life process, not just an intellectual exercise — it requires a person whose heart is oriented toward God, whose spirit is responsive to the Holy Spirit, and whose will is bent toward obedience. Trusting scripture, then, is not just an affective development; it's the affective gateway to spiritual development broadly. When a disciple moves from treating scripture as an interesting old text to organizing their life around it, something has happened in the heart that ripples outward into every other dimension of the person. That's why this is the right place to start.

Measuring trust has its own challenges. Campbell et al. (2021) offer a useful framework around epistemic trust — trust in communicated knowledge — developed in the context of therapeutic relationships. Their three dimensions (trust, mistrust, and credulity) and their connection to attachment theory provide a sophisticated reference point. For the purposes of this pilot, I'm using a simpler self-report continuum alongside observed behavior change, but the attachment-theory framework is worth developing in follow-up research.

The Affective Taxonomy Applied to Heart Formation

Krathwohl et al. (1964) organized affective development across five levels, each representing a deeper degree of internalization: Receiving, Responding, Valuing, Organization, and Characterization by a Value Set. These aren't arbitrary categories — they describe a genuine phenomenology of how people actually come to own a value rather than just acknowledge it.

The proposed context for testing this framework is a small group bible study using the PROAPT model (Herman, 2008): Pray, Read, Observe, Apply, Pray, Tell. Herman developed this for college discipleship, but the structure generalizes well to adult groups. Rynsburger and Lamport (2009) add important grounding in the role of the Holy Spirit within this kind of small group process — the transformation isn't just pedagogical; the Holy Spirit is the agent of growth, and the disciple's part is learning to listen and respond. The PROAPT method structures that learning well.

Here is how the five stages actually map onto a small group session:

Receiving begins simply with showing up. A new participant willing to sit in a room where people pray and discuss scripture has already crossed an important threshold. The Read phase of PROAPT targets this stage — factual, low-risk questions about who, what, when, and where in a passage create space for awareness (1.1) and selective attention (1.3) without requiring any personal exposure.

Responding deepens as participants begin engaging rather than just observing. The shift from answering fact questions to venturing interpretations — “what do you think this means?” — marks the transition from acquiescence in responding (2.1) to willingness and then satisfaction in responding (2.2, 2.3). The Observe phase of PROAPT is designed precisely to invite this.

Valuing is where things start to get personal. The Apply phase asks participants to connect interpretation to their own lives. This is when a disciple begins to accept scripture's authority over their specific situation (3.1), prefer its guidance (3.2), and commit to it (3.3). Observable behavior changes should begin appearing at this stage — not just verbal acknowledgment but actual life adjustments that group members and external witnesses can notice.

Organization involves integrating scriptural values into a coherent personal framework. The disciple is no longer responding to individual passages but is building a biblical worldview. This is the stage where patterns — including patterns of sin — get addressed systematically rather than situationally.

Characterization by a Value Set is Barna's (2003) endpoint: a person whose life outcomes are visibly different because their entire orientation has been reorganized around scripture. The Tell component of PROAPT points toward this — a person who is excited to share what has happened to them is demonstrating Stage 5 formation, not just cognitive assent. Job 42:5 captures it: moving from hearing about God to seeing him directly.

Assessment runs on two tracks throughout: a self-report seven-point Likert scale capturing trust level at regular intervals, and observed behavior reports from small group members and external witnesses (spouse, close friend) chosen by the disciple. The external witness component is not incidental — it introduces the metacognitive dimension that Krathwohl (2002) added to the updated Cognitive Taxonomy, and it keeps the process grounded in community rather than individual introspection alone.

What This Opens Up

The immediate research extension is obvious: run the pilot. Test the construct with real disciples in a real small group and evaluate whether the taxonomy framework actually helps coaches and participants set meaningful objectives and assess progress with a common language. That's straightforward.

The more interesting extensions reach outward. Agape love — the full first and second commandment — is multidimensional in ways that 1 Corinthians 13 alone makes clear. The fruits of the Spirit, personal evangelism, and service to neighbor all have affective developmental trajectories that could be mapped using this framework. But the deeper extension is the one I started with: the spirit and soul dimensions of the person still need their own taxonomies. What does progressive formation of the human spirit look like as an objective-setting framework? What does soul integration mean as a measurable developmental trajectory?

The integrated picture — heart, mind, body, soul, and spirit each with their own developmental framework, and all the taxonomies speaking to each other — is what I'm building toward. The cognitive and affective domains already interact in ways that Miller (2005) and the ASCE work (Lynch et al., 2009) have documented in secular educational settings. Nikolic et al. (2023) showed that even engineering laboratory work involves all three existing taxonomies in non-trivial ways. The integration possibilities for spiritual formation are at least as rich.

Smith (2009, 2013) is important here too. His argument that we are affective animals shaped by what we love — and that Christian education must therefore attend to the formation of desire, not just the transfer of doctrine — is not a peripheral point. It is the anthropological claim that makes this whole project necessary. Training the heart is not supplemental to training the mind; it is prior to it in the order of transformation. The heart's orientation determines what the mind will do with what it learns.

That's the case this paper makes, and it's why the Affective Taxonomy, for all its limitations and need for updating, is the right starting point for the heart piece of the larger formation framework. It gives us the language to say what stage a disciple is at, what the next step looks like, and how we'd know if they got there. For coaches and disciples who are serious about the journey, that's not a small thing.

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